Black September

Palestinian extremists later got their revenge by murdering the Jordanian Prime Minister while he was in Egypt. The killers were members of a group called **Black September**, named after the month in which the Palestinian bases in Jordan were wiped out. Soon they began sending letter bombs to Israeli embassies in Europe.

Then, on 5 September 1972, they stunned the whole world. They attacked the Israeli athletes who were competing in the Olympic Games in Germany. They killed two athletes and then demanded the release of 200 Palestinian prisoners in Israel. When German police attempted a rescue, the Palestinians killed nine more athletes. The Palestinians got the massive publicity they wanted for their cause but not the release of their comrades. A few days later the Israelis took their revenge and carried out reprisal raids on Syria and Lebanon, in which over 200 refugees were killed.

Key term
Black September
A Palestinian group which killed 11 Israeli athletes at the 1972 Olympics.

Key date
Israeli athletes killed at the Olympic Games: 1972

The effects on world opinion

Acts of terrorism made the Palestinians unpopular in the rest of the world. People were shocked by such brutal deeds. They branded the PLO, as a whole, as terrorists. However, terrorist acts made many people in Europe and other parts of the world begin to think more about the Palestinian problem. They read about the crowded, unhealthy camps in which hundreds of thousands of refugees had lived for 20 years. They came to understand that the Palestinian people were the helpless victims of war and asked themselves whether the guerrillas were in fact terrorists or freedom fighters.

Key question
What did the PLO achieve by using terrorism?

Terrorists or freedom fighters?

What reasons are given for the use of violence by each of the Palestinians quoted below?

George Habash, leader of the PFLP, said:

> When we hijack a plane it has more effect than if we killed 100 Israelis in battle. For decades world public opinion has been neither for nor against the Palestinians. It simply ignored us. At least the world is talking about us now.

In the early 1970s, Sami el-Karami, a Palestinian, said:

> The non-violent methods are very beautiful and very easy, and we wish we could win with these methods. Our people do not carry machine guns and bombs because they enjoy killing. It is for us the last resort. For 22 years we have waited for the United Nations and the United States, for liberty, for freedom and democracy. There was no result. So this is our last resort.

A Palestinian student in Lebanon wrote to his parents in 1968:

> For 20 years our people have been waiting for a just solution to the Palestinian problem. All that we got was charity and humiliation